

The Poems

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Introduction to Poetry

Billy Collins

This poem teaches you how to read poems without forcing them. Notice how Collins uses simple metaphors (a room, a beehive, a body) to explain a big idea. As a baby writer, see how humor and clarity can carry an argument.

I ask them to take a poem
and hold it up to the light
like a color slide
or press an ear against its hive.
I say drop a mouse into a poem
and watch him probe his way out,
or walk inside the poem's room
and feel the walls for a light switch.
I want them to waterski
across the surface of a poem
waving at the author's name on the shore.
But all they want to do
is tie the poem to a chair with rope
and torture a confession out of it.
They begin beating it with a hose
to find out what it really means.

Scheherazade

Richard Siken

Pay attention to repetition and intensity. The poem feels urgent, almost breathless. Notice how Siken uses myth and storytelling to talk about fear and desire without explaining everything outright. Notice the title? What does it add to the poem?

Tell me about the dream where we pull the bodies out of the lake
and dress them in warm clothes again.

How it was late, and no one could sleep, the horses running
until they forget that they are horses.

It's not like a tree where the roots have to end somewhere,
it's more like a song on a policeman's radio,
how we rolled up the carpet so we could dance, and the days
were bright red, and every time we kissed there was another apple
to slice into pieces.

Look at the light through the windowpane. That means it's noon, that means
we're inconsolable.

Tell me how all this, and love too, will ruin us.
These, our bodies, possessed by light.

Tell me we'll never get used to it.

Someday I'll Love Ocean Vuong

Ocean Vuong

This poem pays homage to Frank O'Hara's "Katy", with the original line "Someday, I'll Frank O'Hara." This poem speaks gently to the self. Notice the tenderness of the images and how the poem moves slowly through care, memory, and survival. Watch how line breaks create pauses for reflection.

Ocean, don't be afraid.
The end of the road is so far ahead
it is already behind us.
Don't worry. Your father is only your father
until one of you forgets. Like how the spine
won't remember its wings
no matter how many times our knees
kiss the pavement. Ocean,
are you listening? The most beautiful part
of your body is wherever
your mother's shadow falls.
Here's the house with childhood
whittled down to a single red trip wire.
Don't worry. Just call it horizon
& you'll never reach it.
Here's today. Jump. I promise it's not
a lifeboat. Here's the man
whose arms are wide enough to gather
your leaving. & here the moment,
just after the lights go out, when you can still see
the faint torch between his legs.
How you use it again & again
to find your own hands.
You asked for a second chance
& are given a mouth to empty out of.
Don't be afraid, the gunfire
is only the sound of people

trying to live a little longer
& failing. Ocean. Ocean —
get up. The most beautiful part of your body
is where it's headed. & remember,
loneliness is still time spent
with the world. Here's
the room with everyone in it.
Your dead friends passing
through you like wind
through a wind chime. Here's a desk
with the gimp leg & a brick
to make it last. Yes, here's a room
so warm & blood-close,
I swear, you will wake —
& mistake these walls
for skin.

from Frank

Diane Seuss

This poem is about *not doing* something. Notice how hesitation becomes the heart of the poem. As a writer, see how withholding information can be just as powerful as telling it. Read closely the last line; how are you supposed to answer a question like that?

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I drove all the way to Cape Disappointment but didn't
have the energy to get out of the car. Rental. Blue Ford
Focus. I had to stop in a semipublic place to pee
on the ground. Just squatted there on the roadside.
I don't know what's up with my bladder. I pee and then
I have to pee and pee again. Instead of sightseeing
I climbed into the back seat of the car and took a nap.
I'm a little like Frank O'Hara without the handsome
nose and penis and the New York School and Larry
Rivers. Paid for a day pass at Cape Disappointment
thinking hard about that long drop from the lighthouse
to the sea. Thought about going into the Ocean
Medical Center for a check-up but how do I explain
this restless search for beauty or relief?

Jology

Paolo Manalo

I want you to go in blind here. Hint 1: only a Pinoy can understand this poem. Hint 2: translation or transliteration?

O, how dead you child are, whose spoiled

Sportedness is being fashion showed

Beautifuling as we speak -- in Cubao

There is that same look: Your Crossing Ibabaw,

Your Nepa Cute, Wednesdays

Baclaran, "Please pass. Kindly ride on."

Tonight will be us tomorrowed-

Lovers of the Happy Meal and its H,

Who dream of the importedness of sex as long as it's

Pirated and under a hundred, who can smell

A Pasig Raver in a dance club. O, the toilet

Won't flush, but we are moved, doing the gerby

In a plastic bag; we want to feel the grooves
Of the records, we want to hear some scratch-

In a breakaway movement, we're the shake
To the motive of pockets, to the max.

The change is all in the first jeep
Of the morning's route. Rerouting

This city and its heart attacks; one minute faster
Than four o'clock, and the next

Wave that stands out in the outdoor crowd
hanging with a bunch of yo-yos-

A face with an inverted cap on, wearing all
Smiles the smell of foot stuck between the teeth.

Longing: A Documentary

Anne Carson

This poem feels like research rather than confession. Notice how fragments, quotations, and distance create emotion indirectly. As a writer, see how form can shape feeling. How does its form, as a shot list from a movie, help the poem?

Shot List

1. Night.
River.

subtitle: *It was for such a night she had waited.*

2. Trunk of her car is open and lit by a funnel of light from the porch.

3. She loads the trunk: 4×6 trays, photographic papers, strobe light.
Strobe doesn't fit, she angles it into the backseat.

4. She is driving, concentrating, empty highway.

subtitle: *She was not a person who aimed at eventual reconciliation with the views of common sense.*

5. She is at the river in deep reeds, watching.

6. She wades along the edge of the river, watching.

7. Night plucks her, she stumbles, stops.

8. She is bending beside the car, unpacking trays.

9. She drags the trays through deep reeds toward the river.
Moon unclouds itself and plunges by.

subtitle: *Night is not a fact.*

10. She walks into the river.

subtitle: *Facts lack something, she thought.*

11. She positions the big trays on the riverbottom near the bank, just under the water, spreads photographic papers in them, adjusts it, moves back.
Watches.

12. She stands by the strobe in deep reeds.

13. Flash of strobe surprises the riverbank.

14. She sits awhile in the reeds, arms on knees.

subtitle: *"Overtakelessness" (what facts lack).*

15. Moonlight sways down through black water onto the photographic papers.

16. She is driving, windows blowing, empty highways.

subtitle: *As usual she enjoyed the sense of work, of having worked.
Other fears would soon return.*

Celestial Music

Louise Glück

Pay attention to quietness and restraint. The images are simple but careful. Notice how the poem trusts silence and understatement instead of dramatic language.

I have a friend who still believes in heaven.

Not a stupid person, yet with all she knows, she literally talks to god,
she thinks someone listens in heaven.

On earth, she's unusually competent.

Brave, too, able to face unpleasantness.

We found a caterpillar dying in the dirt, greedy ants crawling over it.

I'm always moved by weakness, by disaster, always eager to oppose vitality.

But timid, also, quick to shut my eyes.

Whereas my friend was able to watch, to let events play out
according to nature. For my sake, she intervened,
brushing a few ants off the torn thing, and set it down across the road.

My friend says I shut my eyes to god, that nothing else explains
my aversion to reality. She says I'm like the child who buries her head in the pillow
so as not to see, the child who tells herself
that light causes sadness—

My friend is like the mother. Patient, urging me
to wake up an adult like herself, a courageous person—

In my dreams, my friend reproaches me. We're walking

on the same road, except it's winter now;
she's telling me that when you love the world you hear celestial music:
look up, she says. When I look up, nothing.
Only clouds, snow, a white business in the trees
like brides leaping to a great height—
Then I'm afraid for her; I see her
caught in a net deliberately cast over the earth—

In reality, we sit by the side of the road, watching the sun set;
from time to time, the silence pierced by a birdcall.
It's this moment we're both trying to explain, the fact
that we're at ease with death, with solitude.
My friend draws a circle in the dirt; inside, the caterpillar doesn't move.
She's always trying to make something whole, something beautiful, an image
capable of life apart from her.
We're very quiet. It's peaceful sitting here, not speaking, the composition
fixed, the road turning suddenly dark, the air
going cool, here and there the rocks shining and glittering—
it's this stillness that we both love.
The love of form is a love of endings.

self portrait as a 90s R&B video

Danez Smith

This poem uses comparison as structure. Notice how pop imagery helps the speaker talk about identity, desire, and survival. Pay attention to the rhythm and repetition that give the poem its energy.

lately i've been opening doors in slow motion
& find myself wearing loose white silks
in rooms packed with wind machines & dusk.

i have a tendency to be sad near windows
thinking of all the problems i have
with my man with his triffin yellow ass.

my man is more a concept than anything.
at dinner i watch red-pepper soup spill
onto his powder-blue button-down

& ask, why don't you love me anymore?
i sit on the couch with a wine glass full
of milk, cry in ways that frame me gorgeous

& fuckable. my girls come over & we light
his suits to spark our spliffs. my best bitch
tells me i need to get over him, say he don't

even exist, but what she know? i have all this
house to walk through, all these gowns to cry
on, all these windows to watch the rain.

there must be a man in this house who loves me
too much to do it well. there's a room
in my basement filled with water & gold & that's it.

water up to my well-managed waist
gold-link chains curl around my ankles
like a boa constrictor or the hands of a man

around a neck he once loved to bite.
i dip my head in, let even my hair get wet
& rise out the water Hood Venus

Afrodite, ghetto god with iced-out ropes draped
from my head & arms, covering my nipples
& ill nana just so. i could be a trophy for some

award show only niggas know, every rapper's
favorite ex, 1996 given a body & he don't
want this? i walk into my foyer cause i have

a foyer & say who is she, nigga? i promise
the hydrangeas flinch. my man is so fake
he don't exist. my girls was right—the suits

we lit were mine, my man is all in my head
& it's a bad head. tomorrow, after i run
& spend some time studying the mirror

i'll burn this whole shit down
like Left Eye would, like any good wife.
whatever survives will be my kingdom.

i hope i make it.

The Colonel

Carolyn Forché

Read this as a poem of witnessing. Notice the plain language and shocking images. As a writer, observe how the poem refuses decoration and lets facts carry the weight.

WHAT YOU HAVE HEARD is true. I was in his house. His wife carried a tray of coffee and sugar. His daughter filed her nails, his son went out for the night. There were daily papers, pet dogs, a pistol on the cushion beside him. The moon swung bare on its black cord over the house. On the television was a cop show. It was in English. Broken bottles were embedded in the walls around the house to scoop the kneecaps from a man's legs or cut his hands to lace. On the windows there were gratings like those in liquor stores. We had dinner, rack of lamb, good wine, a gold bell was on the table for calling the maid. The maid brought green mangoes, salt, a type of bread. I was asked how I enjoyed the country. There was a brief commercial in Spanish. His wife took everything away. There was some talk then of how difficult it had become to govern. The parrot said hello on the terrace. The colonel told it to shut up, and pushed himself from the table. My friend said to me with his eyes: say nothing. The colonel returned with a sack used to bring groceries home. He spilled many human ears on the table. They were like dried peach halves. There is no other way to say this. He took one of them in his hands, shook it in our faces, dropped it into a water glass. It came alive there. I am tired of fooling around he said. As for the rights of anyone, tell your people they can go fuck them-

selves. He swept the ears to the floor with his arm and held the last of his wine in the air. Something for your poetry, no? he said. Some of the ears on the floor caught this scrap of his voice. Some of the ears on the floor were pressed to the ground.

May 1978

My Tattoo

Mark Doty

Notice how close attention to the body leads to emotional depth. The poem is patient—nothing is rushed, and at its center is a single metaphor, glittering.

I thought I wanted to wear the Sacred Heart, to represent education through suffering,

how we're pierced to flame.

But when I cruised the inkshop's dragons,

cobalt tigers and eagles in billowy smokes, my allegiance wavered.

Butch lexicon,

anchors and arrows, a sailor's iconic charms—

tempting, but none of them me. What noun would you want

spoken on your skin your whole life through?

I tried to picture what

I'd never want erased and saw a fire-ring corona of spiked rays,

flaring tongues

surrounding—an emptiness, an open space?

I made my mind up.

I sat in the waiting room chair.

Then something (my nerve?

faith in the guy

with biker boots

and indigo hands?)

wavered. It wasn't fear; nothing hurts like grief, and I'm used to that.

His dreaming needle was beside the point; don't I already bear

the etched and flaring marks of an inky trade?

What once was skin

has turned to something made; written and revised beneath these sleeves:

hearts and banners, daggers and flowers and names.

I fled. Then I came back again;

isn't there always a little more room on the skin? It's too late

to be unwritten,

and I'm much too scrawled to ever be erased.

Go ahead: prick and stipple and ink me in:

I'll never be naked again.

From here on out,

I wear the sun,

albeit blue.

Meditations in an Emergency

Cameron Awkward-Rich

Notice how personal thought exists alongside danger and crisis. The poem moves between inner reflection and the outside world. Watch how the speaker's thinking becomes the poem's structure.

I wake up & it breaks my heart. I draw the blinds & the thrill of rain breaks my heart. I go outside. I ride the train, walk among the buildings, men in Monday suits. The flight of doves, the city of tents beneath the underpass, the huddled mass, old women hawking roses, & children all of them, break my heart. There's a dream I have in which I love the world. I run from end to end like fingers through her hair. There are no borders, only wind. Like you, I was born. Like you, I was raised in the institution of dreaming. Hand on my heart. Hand on my stupid heart."

Rape Joke

Patricia Lockwood

This poem uses humor to expose cruelty. Notice the casual tone and how it makes the subject even more disturbing. As a writer, see how voice and timing can create moral force.

The rape joke is that you were 19 years old.

The rape joke is that he was your boyfriend.

The rape joke it wore a goatee. A goatee.

Imagine the rape joke looking in the mirror, perfectly reflecting back itself, and grooming itself to look more like a rape joke. “Ahhhh,” it thinks. “Yes. A goatee.”

No offense.

The rape joke is that he was seven years older. The rape joke is that you had known him for years, since you were too young to be interesting to him. You liked that use of the word interesting, as if you were a piece of knowledge that someone could be desperate to acquire, to assimilate, and to spit back out in different form through his goateed mouth.

Then suddenly you were older, but not very old at all.

The rape joke is that you had been drinking wine coolers. Wine coolers! Who drinks wine coolers? People who get raped, according to the rape joke.

The rape joke is he was a bouncer, and kept people out for a living.

Not you!

The rape joke is that he carried a knife, and would show it to you, and would turn it over and over in his hands as if it were a book.

He wasn't threatening you, you understood. He just really liked his knife.

The rape joke is he once almost murdered a dude by throwing him through a plate-glass window. The next day he told you and he was trembling, which you took as evidence of his sensitivity.

How can a piece of knowledge be stupid? But of course you were so stupid.

The rape joke is that sometimes he would tell you you were going on a date and then take you over to his best friend Pee-wee's house and make you watch wrestling while they all got high.

The rape joke is that his best friend was named Pee-wee.

OK, the rape joke is that he worshiped The Rock.

Like the dude was completely in love with The Rock. He thought it was so great what he could do with his eyebrow.

The rape joke is he called wrestling "a soap opera for men." Men love drama too, he assured you.

The rape joke is that his bookshelf was just a row of paperbacks about serial killers. You mistook this for an interest in history, and laboring under this misapprehension you once gave him a copy of Günter Grass's *My Century*, which he never even tried to read.

It gets funnier.

The rape joke is that he kept a diary. I wonder if he wrote about the rape in it.

The rape joke is that you read it once, and he talked about another girl. He called her Miss Geography, and said "he didn't have those urges when he looked at her anymore," not since he met you. Close call, Miss Geography!

The rape joke is that he was your father's high-school student—your father taught World Religion. You helped him clean out his classroom at the end of the year, and he let you take home the most beat-up textbooks.

The rape joke is that he knew you when you were 12 years old. He once helped your family move two states over, and you drove from Cincinnati to St. Louis with him, all by yourselves, and he was kind to you, and you talked the whole way. He had chaw in his mouth the entire time, and you told him he was disgusting and he laughed, and spat the juice through his goatee into a Mountain Dew bottle.

The rape joke is that come on, you should have seen it coming. This rape joke is practically writing itself.

The rape joke is that you were facedown. The rape joke is you were wearing a pretty green necklace that your sister had made for you. Later you cut that necklace up. The mattress felt a specific way, and your mouth felt a specific way open against it, as if you were speaking, but you know you were not. As if your mouth were open ten years into the future, reciting a poem called Rape Joke.

The rape joke is that time is different, becomes more horrible and more habitable, and accommodates your need to go deeper into it.

Just like the body, which more than a concrete form is a capacity.

You know the body of time is elastic, can take almost anything you give it, and heals quickly.

The rape joke is that of course there was blood, which in human beings is so close to the surface.

The rape joke is you went home like nothing happened, and laughed about it the next day and the day after that, and when you told people you laughed, and that was the rape joke.

It was a year before you told your parents, because he was like a son to them. The rape joke is that when you told your father, he made the sign of the cross over you and said, "I absolve you of your sins, in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit," which even in its total wrongheadedness, was so completely sweet.

The rape joke is that you were crazy for the next five years, and had to move cities, and had to move states, and whole days went down into the sinkhole of thinking about why it happened. Like you went to look at your backyard and suddenly it wasn't there, and you were looking down into the center of the earth, which played the same red event perpetually.

The rape joke is that after a while you weren't crazy anymore, but close call, Miss Geography.

The rape joke is that for the next five years all you did was write, and never about yourself, about anything else, about apples on the tree, about islands, dead poets and the worms that aerated them, and there was no warm body in what you wrote, it was elsewhere.

The rape joke is that this is finally artless. The rape joke is that you do not write artlessly.

The rape joke is if you write a poem called Rape Joke, you're asking for it to become the only thing people remember about you.

The rape joke is that you asked why he did it. The rape joke is he said he didn't know, like what else would a rape joke say? The rape joke said YOU were the one who was drunk, and the rape joke said you remembered it wrong, which made you laugh out loud for one long split-open second. The wine coolers weren't Bartles & Jaymes, but it would be funnier for the rape joke if they were. It was some pussy flavor, like Passionate Mango or Destroyed Strawberry, which you drank down without question and trustingly in the heart of Cincinnati Ohio.

Can rape jokes be funny at all, is the question.

Can any part of the rape joke be funny. The part where it ends—haha, just kidding! Though you did dream of killing the rape joke for years, spilling all of its blood out, and telling it that way.

The rape joke cries out for the right to be told.

The rape joke is that this is just how it happened.

The rape joke is that the next day he gave you Pet Sounds. No really. Pet Sounds. He said he was sorry and then he gave you Pet Sounds. Come on, that's a little bit funny.

Admit it.